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Top draw: Sinner became the first man to win his first two major titles in the same year since Guillermo Vilas, another Argentine, in 1977, and Jimmy Connors captured three in 1974. *AFP*

this year's Australian Open champion, would ensure that the remaining half of the new Big Two (Sinner-Alcaraz) reigned. The 23-year-old Italian outclassed a quartet of Americans, a fast-rising Englishman Jack Draper, and No. 5 Daniil Medvedev — who ousted Sinner at Wimbledon.

Those who thought Sinner would be distracted by the controversy swirling around his two failed drug tests in March and his exoneration just six days before the US Open were disabused of that notion at the Masters 1000 event in Cincinnati. Sinner outplayed Alexander Zverev, Andrey Rublev, and Frances Tiafoe for his fifth title.

Even so, *ESPN* analyst Mary Joe Fernandez remained optimistic before Championship Sunday. "I love Taylor's chances. Why can't he lift the trophy the way Roddick did?"

Perhaps, Fritz's confidence rubbed off on her. "I have a feeling I'm going to come out and play really well and win," said the 26-year-old Californian. "When I play good tennis, I think that level is good enough to win."

It certainly was against No. 8 Casper Ruud in his convincing 3-6, 6-4, 6-3, 6-2 win over the 2022 US Open finalist and two-time French Open runner-up.

"Fritz is volleying the traditional volley better than ever and his



swinging volley is good," said *ESPN's* John McEnroe, an elite serve-volleyer himself, 40 years ago.

When Fritz edged No. 4 Zverev 7-6, 3-6, 6-4, 7-6 to reach his first Grand Slam semifinal, he recalled his crushing five-set losses at the Majors, saying, "Today it felt different. It was my time to take it a step farther." Patience and composure proved critical, especially in the tiebreakers, against the rocket-serving but otherwise mostly passive German baseliner. This was Fritz's fourth top-10 win at a Major this year, the most by an American man since Andre Agassi in 1999. "We

Full of promise: "Fritz (in pic) is volleying the traditional volley better than ever and his swinging volley is good," said John McEnroe, an elite serve-volleyer himself. *AP*

all want to be the one to end it," he said, referring to America's 21-year drought in winning a men's singles Major.

When asked if chants of "USA, USA" helped him, the appreciative Fritz left no doubt about his feelings. "The crowd support is amazing. They're helping so much in all my matches."

Fans would have divided loyalties, though, in the semis between Fritz and his good friend Tiafoe, the 2022 semifinalist. "When Tiafoe plays, it's as loud as it gets at the US Open," said Darren Cahill, a 1988 semifinalist here and now a co-coach for Sinner. That Tiafoe sported a New York Knicks jersey in afternoon practice sessions, and his girlfriend, a New York Rangers cap, showed his savvy in courting fans in this



Novak Djokovic's loss to Alexei Popyrin meant that, for the first time since 2002, no member of the legendary Big Three would capture a Grand Slam title in the same year